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Prof. Atif Mian
Princeton University

RE: AER-2024-0087.R1: Falling Rates and Rising Superstars

Dear Professor Mian,

I solicited four expert reviews on your revised paper entitled “Falling Rates and Rising Superstars”, submitted for publication at the *American Economic Review*. Three reports are attached.

Unfortunately, I do not have good news. The original positive referee remains positive. However, none of the other referees are positive. One of the original negative referees has become more negative, emphasizing a lack of robustness in your empirical analysis. A second negative referee from the first round declined to provide an additional report at the stage. Given the situation, I decided to solicit feedback from a fourth referee, but this referee is also skeptical of the robustness of the empirical results.

I want you to know that this was a very difficult decision for me. Rejecting a paper in the second round is not something I take at all lightly, and it pains me greatly to do this (even though I had flagged this as a tough revision). However, I feel that this is the best decision at this stage in the revision process, given a realistic assessment of the likely outcomes going forward.

I continue to find your paper interesting and engaging. If this were the first round, I might consider inviting a further revision. Given that this is already the second round, however, I feel that there is too much distance and uncertainty between the current draft and what I believe is likely to be published for me to feel comfortable doing this.

I know that this is not the news you were hoping for. While you may not agree with all the referee comments, I do hope you find them useful as you revise the paper for submission to another journal.

Personally, I think a revised version of your paper could be a strong candidate for a top field journal such as *AEJ Macro* if you decided to submit it there (but of course, the Editors at *AEJ Macro* make their own decisions). If you decide to go this direction, I believe it would be important to respond to some of the referees’ concerns regarding the robustness of the empirical results. Of course, you may decide to try your hand at another top general interest journal.

Thank you very much for giving us the opportunity to consider your fine paper.

Regards,

Emi Nakamura
Coeditor
American Economic Review